

AI Opportunity Brief

Message-first draft for Absolute Mechanical

Prepared for Absolute Mechanical

Prepared by Lawrence Tweed

Draft purpose: confirm what we heard, frame the practical opportunity, and define the next scoping conversation.

Executive Message

The strongest near-term opportunity is not to start by trying to “use AI” across the business. The more useful first move is to create a clearer visibility layer around the work that is already happening: jobs, buildings, equipment, drawings, photos, access notes, field updates, next actions, and follow-ups.

That visibility layer could eventually be supported by generative AI, and it may even be built with the help of generative AI tools. But the business value is not the AI by itself. The value is making the right information easier to find, easier to trust, and easier to act on from the office or the field.

This memo is meant to preserve the discovery logic behind that recommendation, identify the repeated workflow frictions that are showing up, and suggest a disciplined next step before anyone commits to a platform, custom build, or AI-heavy project.

Discovery Synthesis

The discovery responses seem to describe the same business from two different but equally important angles.

Owner / construction lens: visibility, construction workflow, and long-term data value

The Client emphasized the need to see what is happening across active jobs without having to chase the answer through calls, texts, email, paper folders, QuickBooks, server folders, or individual memory. The recurring question is not only “where is someone?” but also “what work is active, who owns it, what capacity exists, what is blocked, and what information should already be connected to this job or building?”

The Client also described a deeper long-term opportunity: Absolute has years of bidding, estimating, job-cost, building, equipment, and proposal history. There may be patterns in that history that could help with faster budgeting, better bid coordination, job-type categories, and improved estimating logic. That is real potential, but it should probably come after the operational visibility layer is clearer.

Office / service lens: execution, maintenance coordination, and field handoffs

The office/service responses make the workflow very concrete. Service calls, preventive maintenance work, construction support, repair follow-ups, TeamUp updates, Dropbox/server files, paper folders, QuickBooks entry, technician notes, photos, and billing handoffs are all connected in practice, but not always connected in one visible system.

Those responses also show where the work gets fragile: repeated manual entry, shared credentials, status updates that depend on people remembering to update TeamUp, photos or notes that live in one place but not another, and follow-ups that can sit in email, text, paper, or someone's head.

Shared center of gravity

Both perspectives point to the same basic need: a practical way to see the current job, building, equipment, documents, access information, status, next action, and follow-up history without having to search several places or ask several people.

That is why I would frame the first opportunity as a visibility and workflow problem before framing it as an AI problem.

The Current Workflow Reality

One of the most important things in the follow-up responses is how many places a single piece of work can touch before a technician or installer has what they need.

- A service call may start by phone, text, or email, then move through a journal, Excel, QuickBooks, TeamUp, a paper folder, technician assignment, and sometimes Dropbox/server context.
- A preventive maintenance visit may move through an Excel list, monthly setup, a journal, QuickBooks, a paper folder, TeamUp, filter vendor coordination, and then technician completion/reporting.
- A construction job may begin as a GC bid invite, walkthrough, sketch, Bluebeam mark-up, estimate/proposal, award, job number, server folder, QuickBooks entry, paper folder, project manager coordination, and field execution.
- A repair follow-up may begin with a technician diagnosis, parts quote request, supply house/manufacture response, office proposal, customer follow-up, approved repair, schedule update, and billing review.
- A bid or pre-job opportunity may never become a formal job, but still contain valuable building, relationship, drawing, pricing, or historical knowledge.

The current process reflects a business that has grown around real work, field autonomy, paper habits, service urgency, customer relationships, and accounting controls. The opportunity is to preserve what works while reducing the number of times people have to check here, check there, call someone, text someone, or search through old files.

What a Visibility Layer Would Mean

A visibility layer does not have to replace TeamUp, Dropbox, QuickBooks, the server, Microsoft tools, paper files, or field judgment on day one. In a first pilot, it could simply create a cleaner view that links or summarizes the information people need most often.

For example, a technician or foreman on a rooftop should be able to pull up the job or building from a phone and see the practical context: address, customer/site contact, project manager or office contact, drawings, roof access, lockbox instructions, equipment list, prior service notes, relevant photos, and what needs to be completed or reported.

For the office, the same layer could make it easier to see whether a service call is complete, whether a repair proposal is needed, whether a parts quote has come back, whether a preventive maintenance report triggered follow-up work, or whether a job is ready for billing review.

For ownership, the same layer could provide a cleaner view of active jobs, who owns them, what is waiting, what capacity might exist, and whether a building or customer has relevant history that should be visible before someone starts from scratch.

Where Generative AI Fits

My role with generative AI is not simply to drop an AI tool into the company. The more useful role is to study the layers of information and workflow: where data lives, how work moves, what people repeatedly ask for, what decisions depend on memory, and where patterns or correlations might create value.

For example, I could study the bidding process and historical bids to understand whether the available information can help Absolute bid more accurately or more quickly. That might include looking at bid invites, estimates, proposal formats, job-cost history, job categories, building types, equipment patterns, labor assumptions, and profitability records.

But that kind of sensemaking should probably be sequenced after the visibility layer. If the current job/building/equipment records are fragmented, the AI analysis will either take longer, require more cleanup, or produce answers that still need heavy human interpretation.

Near-term AI-assisted opportunities

- Extract basic bid invite details from emails: GC, GC project manager, job name, address, walkthrough date, and bid due date.
- Turn technician notes into cleaner draft language for office review before invoice or proposal language is sent to a customer.
- Summarize building/equipment history from approved records so field staff and office staff can quickly see relevant context.
- Help organize old inspection reports, startup sheets, photos, equipment lists, and roof drawings around buildings and equipment.
- Later, study estimating and job-cost history for patterns in job type, square footage, equipment, labor assumptions, and profitability.

Important guardrail

AI should assist approved workflows. It should not become the source of truth, automatically send customer-facing invoices or proposals, or touch QuickBooks Desktop, payroll, banking, margin, or sensitive financial information in an early phase.

Likely Paths to Consider

There are several possible paths, and the right answer may be a combination. I would keep the comparison brief and practical.

Current-system improvements

Absolute could improve some pain points by tightening existing processes: naming conventions, job intake rules, TeamUp conventions, Dropbox/server folder rules, completion status, repair follow-up queues, and offboarding/access practices. This is useful, but it may not create the mobile job visibility layer the Client appears to be considering.

Off-the-shelf contractor software

Off-the-shelf contractor software may offer dispatch, service history, work orders, forms, inventory, invoicing, and field workflows. It is worth checking the category so the box is covered. The caution is that Absolute appears to be trying to preserve construction autonomy and avoid forcing the whole company into a rigid service-dispatch model.

Microsoft-based options

Because Absolute has Microsoft 365 licenses, it may be worth scoping whether SharePoint, Lists, Forms, Power Apps, or related Microsoft tools could support controlled records, permissions, and simple mobile forms. The caution is that current usage appears mostly desktop-based, so this is not just a technical question. It is also an adoption, support, and workflow-design question.

Custom visibility layer

A custom build may be the most natural fit if the first pilot needs to reflect Absolute's specific mix of construction, service, preventive maintenance, equipment history, field autonomy, office review, and QuickBooks boundaries. The caution is that custom work needs disciplined scoping: what gets built first, what stays out, who maintains it, what it costs, how it is secured, and how people will actually use it.

Recommended First Pilot

I would not start with the whole company. I would start with a small pilot that proves whether the visibility layer is useful in real work.

Pilot should include

- 3-5 representative jobs or buildings.
- Job number/name, customer/site, project manager, foreman or technician, status, next action, blocker, and last update.
- Links to current drawings, roof drawings, equipment lists, photos, inspection reports, startup sheets, TeamUp context, Dropbox/server locations, and controlled access notes.
- Simple mobile field inputs: note, photo, completion status, issue found, repair needed, parts quote needed, ready/not ready for office review.
- Role-based permissions: who can view, who can add, who can edit master records, and who can see sensitive access information.

Defer or restrict for now

- Deep QuickBooks integration.
- Payroll, banking, margin, customer pricing, or full job-cost exposure.
- AP/lien waiver automation.
- Full TeamUp replacement.

- Full Dropbox/server migration.
- Automatic customer-facing invoices or proposals.
- Company-wide rollout.
- Broad historical-data sensemaking or estimating analytics unless the Client explicitly reprioritizes it.

Anticipated Questions to Resolve

1. What would this actually look like? A simple mobile-first job/building/equipment view, not a final product design yet.
2. How much would it cost? That requires technical scoping around architecture, hosting, security, integrations, maintenance, and pilot size.
3. What happens to TeamUp, Dropbox, QuickBooks, and Microsoft? They likely remain in place initially; the pilot decides what to link, standardize, or leave authoritative.
4. How do we protect sensitive information? Use individual credentials, role/job-based permissions, audit logs, and keep QuickBooks integration out of phase one.
5. How do we get people to use it? Define the adoption rules: who updates what, when updates are expected, what old behavior changes, and why the tool is useful to the field and office.
6. How does this preserve construction autonomy? Design the pilot around job visibility and field usefulness, not personal surveillance or rigid dispatch control.

Suggested Next Step

If this framing feels accurate, the suggested next step is a short scoping call with an AI Systems Architect. The purpose would not be to jump straight into a build. The purpose would be to pressure-test what a first pilot might involve, what it could cost, what should stay out of scope, what security boundaries matter, and whether a custom build, Microsoft-based approach, off-the-shelf option, or hybrid path makes the most sense.

The most useful output from that call would be a simple pilot brief: target workflow, sample jobs/buildings, required fields, source systems, permission model, likely build path, rough cost range, and adoption plan.

The change-management piece matters. A lot of new systems fail because people are given another tool without a clear explanation of what it is for, how it helps them, what it replaces, and who is responsible for keeping it current. That should be part of the pilot design, not an afterthought.